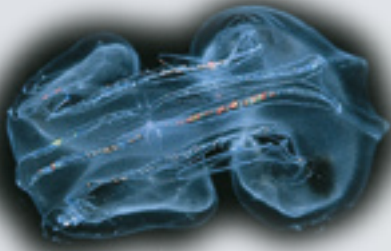


Glossary



Bioluminescence

ABYSSAL PLAIN The flat floor of an ocean basin covered in a layer of sediment. (*see also* BASIN, SEDIMENT)

ANTARCTIC Region at the South Pole, south of the Antarctic Circle.

ARCTIC Region at the North Pole, north of the Arctic Circle.

ATOLL Coral reef surrounding a lagoon, growing on the rim of a sunken volcanic island.

BARRIER REEF Coral reef lying parallel to the shore with a wide, deep strip of water between the land and the reef.

BASIN Large, natural bowl-shaped indentation in the Earth's crust. The Atlantic, Pacific, and Indian Oceans lie in three such basins.

BATHYSCAPHE A deep-diving vessel consisting of a spherical cabin suspended beneath a gas-filled float.

BATHYSPHERE Manned, spherical cabin lowered by a cable; the first diving vessel used to study the deep sea.

BIOLUMINESCENCE Meaning living (bio) light (luminescence)—the production of light by a living organism. Some deep-sea creatures produce their own light. In others, it is produced by bacteria living in them.

BIVALVE Soft-bodied animal living in a hinged shell, such as a clam or oyster.

BLACK SMOKER Tall chimneylike vent on the ocean floor that belches out sulfur-rich, super-hot water stained with dark chemicals, used by some deep-sea creatures to make food. Black smokers occur at volcanically active spots on mid-ocean ridges. (*see also* MID-OCEAN RIDGE)

BONY FISH Fish such as mackerel or cod with a bony skeleton and a swim bladder to control buoyancy.

CARTILAGINOUS FISH Fish such as a shark or ray, with a gristly or cartilaginous skeleton and no swim bladder, meaning it will sink if it doesn't keep moving.

CEPHALOPOD Type of mollusk with a soft body and suckered tentacles, such as a squid.

CONTINENTAL CRUST The Earth's crust that forms the continents.

CONTINENTAL DRIFT Theory that the world's continents were once a single mass of land that slowly drifted apart over millions of years, and are still moving today.

CONTINENTAL SHELF Sloping submerged land at the edge of a continent.

CONTINENTAL SLOPE Sloping submerged land that descends from the continental shelf to the abyssal plain, forming the side of an ocean basin. (*see also* ABYSSAL PLAIN, BASIN)

COPEPOD Tiny shrimplike creature, forming part of the ocean's zooplankton. (*see also* ZOOPLANKTON)



Krill

CRINOID Sea lily that grows on the seabed below 330 ft (100 m); a relative of the feather star.

CRUSTACEAN Animal, such as a lobster or a crab, with jointed legs and a tough, jointed outer skeleton over its body.

CURRENT Body of water that flows through the sea; there are both surface and deep water currents.

DARK ZONE Area of the ocean bordered by the twilight zone above and the abyss below, from around 3,300 and 13,200 ft (1,000 and 4,000 m). Also called the bathypelagic zone. The only light in this zone is from bioluminescent organisms. (*see also* BIOLUMINESCENCE)

DIATOM Single-celled alga and type of phytoplankton that floats near the ocean's surface, forming the basis of an ocean food chain or food web; common in cool waters.

DINOFLLAGELLATE Single-celled alga and a type of phytoplankton, common in warm, tropical waters.

DNA Short for deoxyribonucleic acid—the primary genetic material of a cell that makes up genes and chromosomes.

DORSAL FIN Fin on the back of a fish that helps it keep its balance as it swims.

ECHINODERM Marine invertebrate with spines in the skin, such as a starfish.

EL NINO Warm water current that flows east toward the western coast of South America every few years, causing worldwide weather changes.

FOOD CHAIN Chain or series of plants and animals linked by their feeding relationships. A food chain usually includes algae, or plants, plant-eating animals, and meat-eating animals.

FOOD WEB A series of several interlinked food chains.

FRINGING REEF Reef running along a shoreline, with little or no space between the reef and the land.



Swirling winds of a hurricane forming over the Atlantic